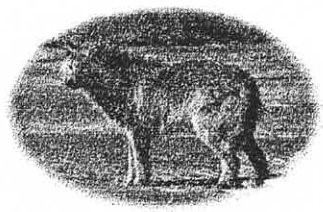
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The Legendary White Wolf



Between Stanford and the Little Belt mountains, which lie to the southwest, ranged the phantom White Wolf. This was his stomping grounds...where he reigned supreme for over fifteen years, although there was a bounty on his head and all men were hunting him. The cattlemen all feared him, as calves were his main supply of food. During the fifteen years that he ruled, he killed thousands of dollars worth of cattle. Although it was hard to tell exactly the number of calves he killed, the Taylor ranch, which lies next to the mountains, estimated they lost in the neighborhood of forty to fifty head of calves and yearlings. The Hughes ranch, which lies south of Stanford, believed they lost nearly as many. The same story held true for the other ranches in the foothills. The Hughes ranch at one time found a newly-killed two-year-steer which he had just finished making a meal of.

It was no wonder then that he became famous and a large bounty placed on his head. As his fame grew, hunters from all over the United States came to try their luck at capturing or killing him. However, he seemed to lead a charmed life and was soon known as the phantom.

Many methods were used to try to get him, and although he had many narrow escapes, it was many years before he was finally killed. At times, dozens of traps were set by expert trappers in his known hunting ground. Also, poison bait was put out but he stayed clear of all traps and ate only freshly killed beef. He seemed to laugh at man's efforts to best him. One rancher imported five Russian wolf hounds and after much searching finally met up with the White Killer. Although outnumbered five to one, the wolf defended himself so savagely that the hounds retreated and he escaped into the timber while the rancher sate helplessly by without a rifle.

After being hunted by so many people for so many years, he developed a cunning that at times seemed almost human. But finally, after fifteen years, he made his one and only known mistake. early one morning a rancher saw him entering the timber after having gorged himself on a freshly-killed calf. The rancher immediately notified his neighbor, Al Close. They set out on his trail with two dogs, a shepard, and a terrier. They cautiously entered the timber where the wolf was last seen, separated and began stalking him. Close's dogs soon picked up the trail and routed him from his bed. The then worked him as if they had been trained to do with coyotes. The terrier attacked and retreated while the shepherd circled and moved the group ever nearer to Mr. Close, who was hiding in the brush waiting, hearing the battle draw nearer. Soon they came into view and although almost immediately the White Wolf saw Mr. Close, he made his one and last mistake. Instead of dashing back to safety, he stood and snarled. The hunter

raised his rifle and fired and the reign of one of the west's worst livestock killers was ended.

The White Wolf was as large as he had been reported, weighing 83 pounds and measuring, including the tail, six feet long. judging from the condition of the teeth which were intact but chipped and work, his age was estimated to be in the neighborhood of eighteen years. Today the White Wolf is mounted and stands in the Basin Trading Post as a reminder to everyone of the bloody, destructive career he led. He can be seen Monday through Saturday from 8 A.M. to 5 P.M.

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